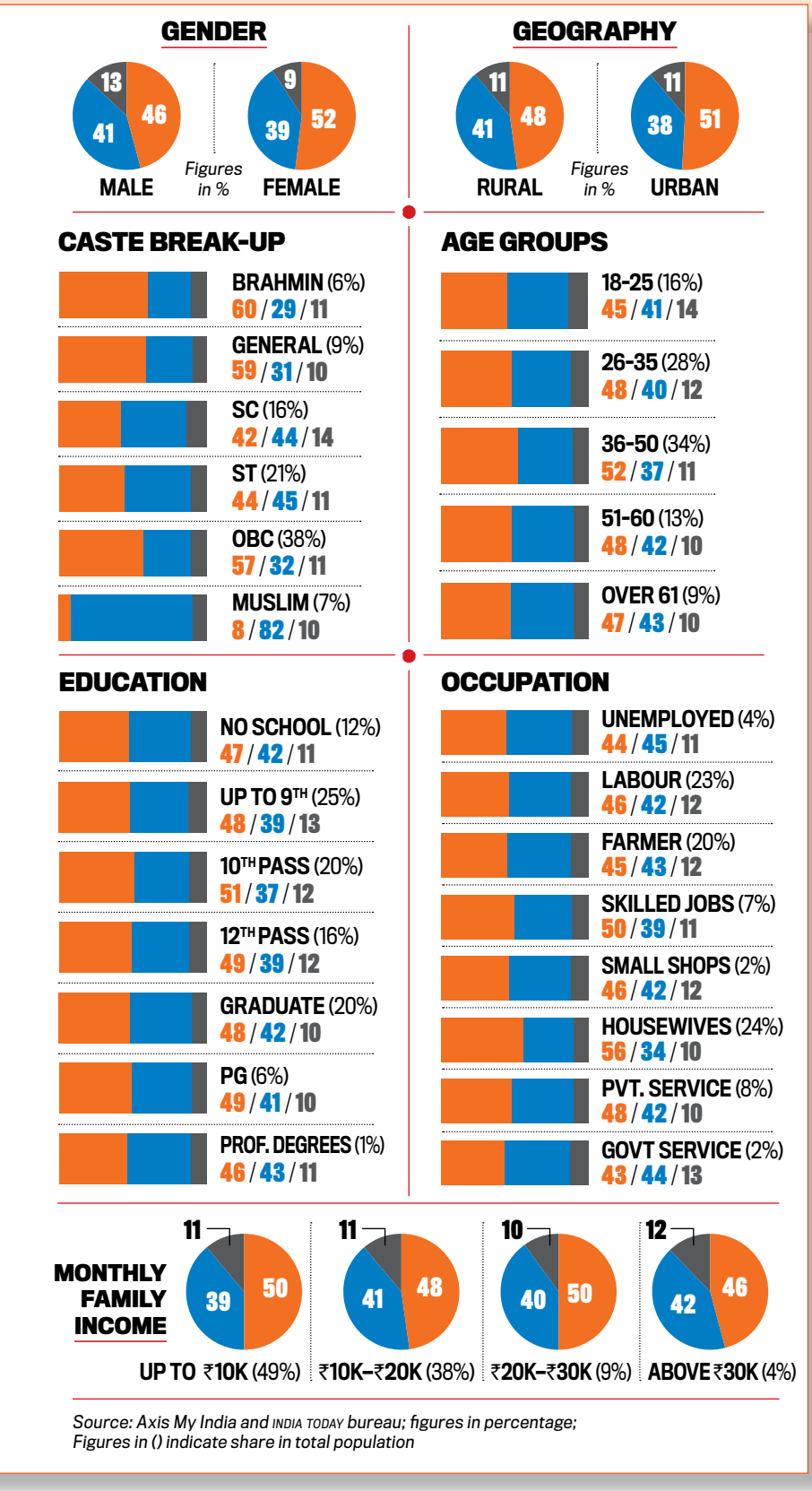


Source: Axis My India and INDIA TODAY bureau; figures in percentage; Figures in () indicate share in total population

THE INDIA TODAY-AXIS MY INDIA EXIT POLL SHOWS THAT THE BJP HAS WON MAINLY BECAUSE OF THE BIG SWING OF WOMEN VOTERS IN ITS FAVOUR

which entailed a payment of Rs 1,500 per month. It even got Congress workers to fill up forms of beneficiaries—to indicate how serious it was about its promise. However, the party's weak organisational base could not ensure the kind of traction Chouhan could for LBY. Not only did he cleverly get the government machinery, mostly panchayat secretaries, to implement the scheme, he later revised the payment to Rs 1,250 a month and promised to eventually take it to Rs 3,000.

'LADLA' OF WOMEN

The India Today-Axis My India exit poll, which predicted the outcome in MP correctly, finds that the BJP has won mainly because of the swing of women voters in its favour. As per the survey, 46 per cent of the male electorate voted for the BJP while 52 per cent of the women did the same. The Congress, on the other hand, got the vote of 41 per cent of the men and only 39 per cent of the women. Per the survey, it is this 13 percentage point difference in the women's vote share that made all the difference in the BJP's performance. The vote share of the BJP among housewives, as per the survey, increased to 56 per cent while it declined for the Congress to 34 per cent.

This wasn't the first time that Chouhan was banking on women to bail him out. In the past 18 years of BJP rule, the state has launched 21 women-centric schemes. "I have always maintained that there was no close contest in MP. We would win by a massive mandate, which we have. Ladli Behna Yojana isn't the only initiative for women in MP; there is reservation in panchayat and urban elected bodies and government jobs, besides schemes for making women financially independent," Chouhan tells INDIA TODAY. "A comprehensive victory such as this isn't only due to women supporting us. All sections of society have voted for us because they were disillusioned with the Congress rule earlier when there were no roads, no schools or colleges or jobs. The Congress had said there was anti-incumbency; in fact, there was pro-incumbency," he adds.

Among the major communities, the exit poll findings suggest, the BJP secured 59 per cent of the general category vote